



fly, and cover with netting. Keep plants weeded and well-watered, and earth up around the stems to provide extra support. Feed with a nitrogenous fertilizer or organic liquid feed in summer.

HARVESTING AND STORING

Harvest sprouts from the bottom of the plant first, and either cut them off with a knife, or snap them off. You could also dig up the whole plant, hang the stem in cool, frost-free place, or stand in a bucket of water, and pick sprouts from it as you need them. The youngest leaves can be picked and eaten as spring greens.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Covering your Brussels sprouts with netting and giving them a brassica collar will minimize the risk of birds, butterflies, and cabbage root fly, which should be controlled as much as possible. The flies attack plant roots and leave them to rot; see pages 246–7 for ways to deal with them. Brussels sprouts are also prone to mealy cabbage aphids and whitefly, which target leaves and will cause them to shrivel. Remove any insects or eggs that you find and spray infected plants with insecticidal soap.